

LOOKING AFTER YOUR GARDEN

To keep your garden in peak condition, you will need to perform regular maintenance tasks throughout the year. Watering is essential for young plants and those in containers, and to win the battle against

weeds you must be vigilant from spring to fall. It pays to give most plants a feed and a mulch every year—usually in spring. Woody plants may also need to be pruned to keep them in good condition.

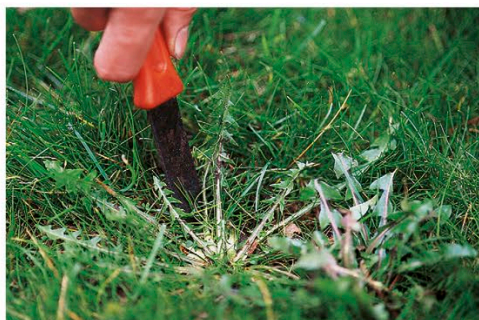
Weeding methods

You can limit the growth of weeds by top-dressing the soil with a thick mulch or a membrane, but you will never be completely free of them. The most useful tool for removing annual weeds over a large area is a hoe; as you move it back and forth, the blade slices through the necks of weeds where the stems meet the soil. Choose a dry, sunny day for hoeing and leave the weeds on the surface to die—you can then gather them up and compost them.

Although hoeing kills annual weeds, such as chickweed and groundsel, perennial weeds, including brambles, dock, couch grass, and ground elder will survive and regrow. Use a weeder to remove those with taproots, such as dandelions, and dig out perennials with fibrous root systems using a spade or trowel. If you have pernicious weeds that you cannot remove by hand, apply a glyphosate weedkiller.

Watering

In summer, watering is the main gardening task. Young plants in beds and borders and container displays are especially vulnerable to drought, and are best watered early in the morning or in the evening when evaporation rates are low. A basic watering can is generally sufficient for small areas or



Dealing with dandelions

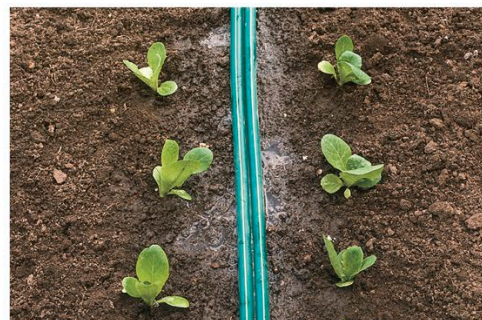
A weeder is the ideal tool for prying out perennial weeds with deep taproots, such as dandelions.

containers, and fits easily under a rain-barrel spigot. For seedlings and new plants, use a can with a fine spray, so that you do not wash soil away from the roots.

If you have a large new area to water, a garden hose is a more practical option. Attach a spray nozzle to give new plantings a gentle shower, and direct the hose on the soil, rather than the leaves or flowers. An even more efficient watering method is to lay perforated hosepipes round your plants; water gradually seeps out at soil level and penetrates deeply with little waste.

Fertilizing

Once established, most plants growing in reasonably good soil need an annual



Slow-release watering

Drip hoses trickle water into the soil above the roots, exactly where it is most needed.

application of fertilizer in spring. The type of plant food you choose and how often you apply it will be determined by your soil and what you are trying to grow. Plants require a range of essential nutrients. The primary nutrients are nitrogen (N), which plants need for leaf growth; phosphorous (P) for healthy roots; and potassium (K) for good flower and fruit production. The secondary nutrients—calcium, magnesium, and sulphur—are required in smaller amounts, while the seven trace elements, such as iron, are needed in very small quantities.

Fertilizers are either organic (derived from plants and animals) or inorganic (chemically manufactured). Most are concentrated for convenience and available

FERTILIZER OPTIONS

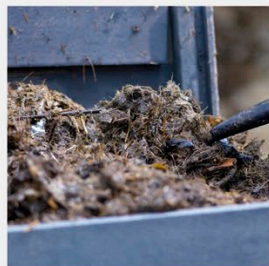
Most plants benefit from an application of fertilizer once a year in spring. However, some may need extra nutrients to boost them at key times, such as flowering. Always follow the manufacturer's instructions carefully

because too much fertilizer, or using the wrong type for a particular plant, may have a detrimental effect. Your local garden center or DIY store will stock a selection of organic and inorganic fertilizers.



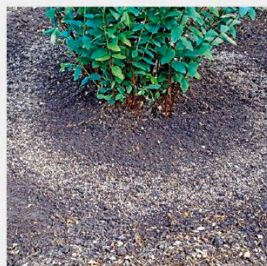
Chemical fertilizer

A balanced chemical fertilizer is used to enrich the soil at sowing or planting time. It can also be applied as an annual top dressing in the spring for all types of plants.



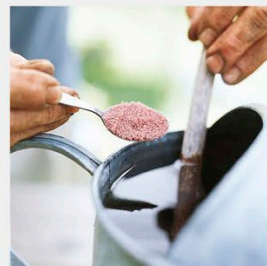
Organic matter

Well-rotted manure or garden compost is rich in trace elements and soil-conditioning substances. Dig it into the ground or apply it as a surface mulch.



Fish, blood and bonemeal

This organic, balanced fertilizer can be mixed into the soil when planting, and applied around plants in the spring or early summer.



Soluble food

Fast-acting soluble liquid fertilizers give bedding and container plants the nutrients they need. They can also be used on plants that need a quick boost.



Slow-release granules

These granules are activated by warmth and moisture, and provide a steady supply of nutrients for many weeks in borders and containers.